



Ai-Lun Fu <ailunfu858@gmail.com>

Question about Arnold Arboretum specimen provenance location information

4 messages

Ailene Ettinger <ailene.ettinger@tnc.org>

Mon, May 18, 2026 at 1:09 PM

To: "mdosmann@oeb.harvard.edu" <mdosmann@oeb.harvard.edu>, "Rosin, Faye M" <frosin@oeb.harvard.edu>

Cc: Elizabeth M Wolkovich <wolkovic@mail.ubc.ca>, Ai-Lun Fu <ailunfu858@gmail.com>

Hello Michael and Faye!

I hope you are well! It has been a while since I have been in touch with you, Michael! I have had the good fortune to reconnect with Faye every year or so recently, which has been lovely.

As you may or may not remember, my Putnum fellow project involved coring arboretum trees to quantify climate sensitivity in relation to tree provenance, traits, and other factors. (I am attaching my research statement, in case it's helpful.) I'm emailing you now because Lizzie Wolkovich and members of her lab, including Ai-Lun Fu (both cc'd), are planning to analyze the tree core data I collected at the Arnold Arboretum as a Putnum fellow (now more than 10 years ago- yikes!). I'm very excited that there is support and interest from their lab to return to this analysis!

We have revisited some of the data outputs I received from you from BG-BASE back in 2014 or so, and we realized that many of the collections are missing specific provenance location data. I am wondering if you have ideas for if/how it might be possible to recover some of these locations, when lat/longs or specific place names are not present? Is it possible that this information might be available from [Arnold Arboretum herbaria specimens](#) or other resources?

I am happy to share additional information or set up a time to chat if that would be helpful. Please let me know if you have any questions or ideas for how we might be able to fill in missing location data.

Thank you!

Best wishes,

Ailene

Ailene Ettinger, PhD

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At TNC we work flexibly. While it suits me to email now, I don't anticipate a response outside of your normal work hours.



ResearchStatement_Ettinger.pdf

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Dosmann, Michael S <mdosmann@oeb.harvard.edu>

Mon, May 18, 2026 at 1:44 PM

To: Ailene Ettinger <ailene.ettinger@tnc.org>, "Rosin, Faye M" <frosin@oeb.harvard.edu>

Cc: Elizabeth M Wolkovich <wolkovic@mail.ubc.ca>, Ai-Lun Fu <ailunfu858@gmail.com>, "Port, Kyle D." <kport@oeb.harvard.edu>

Hi Ailene,

Great to reconnect, and fantastic to learn of the new sets of analyses (Hi Lizzie and Ai-Lun!).

I'm not exactly sure without looking into that 2014 dataset, but I'm wondering if that dataset lacked specific provenance info for individuals simply because we never had it to begin with.

The best way to ground truth would be for you to take your list of accession numbers (the full that includes the letter), put them into a single column in excel (no need for any other columns, or tabs), save it as a .csv, and then upload it into Arboretum Explorer. To do this, go to the site (<https://arboretum.harvard.edu/explorer/>), find your way to MyVisit, and click on the upload link (the diskette with the up arrow). This should show all of your plants on the map. You can THEN download this list and it will include all of the passport data (MyVisit, click the download link with the diskette and down arrow). This will show pretty much everything that we have in the database. You can compare/contrast what that looks like with what you have.

Of course, there are plants that have since died, so they won't be on Explorer, but we can tackle those separately.

How does that sound?

Michael

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Ailene Ettinger <ailene.ettinger@tnc.org>

Mon, May 18, 2026 at 1:55 PM

To: "Dosmann, Michael S" <mdosmann@oeb.harvard.edu>, "Rosin, Faye M" <frosin@oeb.harvard.edu>

Cc: Elizabeth M Wolkovich <wolkovic@mail.ubc.ca>, Ai-Lun Fu <ailunfu858@gmail.com>, "Port, Kyle D." <kport@oeb.harvard.edu>

Thank you for the quick reply, Michael!

Your approach sounds great to me- and very straightforward. I think it is likely that those lacking information are accessions for which you never had that information to begin with.

I was wondering if you think it is worth looking for that information somewhere else (like cross checking with the herbarium)? Or do you think that BGBase info is a good representation of all the available information that you have?

Thank you!

-Ailene

Ailene Ettinger, PhD *she/her*

Senior Research Ecologist



[Quoted text hidden]

Dosmann, Michael S <mdosmann@oeb.harvard.edu>

Mon, May 18, 2026 at 2:25 PM

To: Ailene Ettinger <ailene.ettinger@tnc.org>, "Rosin, Faye M" <frosin@oeb.harvard.edu>

Cc: Elizabeth M Wolkovich <wolkovic@mail.ubc.ca>, Ai-Lun Fu <ailunfu858@gmail.com>, "Port, Kyle D." <kport@oeb.harvard.edu>

Hi Ailene,

Without knowing the accessions with scant information, it is hard to tell. Perhaps start with that list of accessions with potentially more information and we can work from there. The information in BG-BASE is as complete as we have it, but it could be that say in 1898 we received a plant from Kew without much information besides a collector, but the voucher in Kew's herbarium has more info. Similarly, there are historic AA-collected plants that deserve some retroclassification based on info in another database or even locked away in a book.

Let's start with the list of offenders and work from there.

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